

HASHKAMA WEEKLY

פרשת אמור

יד' אייר תשפ"ו

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By Reb Gemini חכמה ב-א תאמין?

Consider the following "Torah" thought, generated by Gemini:
Did the AI get it right?

Do you find

it to be accurate?

Or did the technology miss the boat?

Rabosai, Parshas Emor begins with a special tzivuy to the Kohanim to avoid tumah, specifically tumas meis (Vayikra 21:1). Rashi (Vayikra 21:1) famously points out the double language of "Emor... v'amarta" to warn the adults regarding the children. It is pashut that a Kohen has a higher standard. You see, the Kohen is busy in the Mishkan dealing with kedushah and life, so he cannot associate with death. Sometimes we Litvaks think the pshat is that Hashem just wanted to give them extra chumros so they do not get bored, because what is a respectable Yid without a good chumrah to ruin his weekend plans? But the Emes is, a Kohen represents the absolute vitality of Avodas Hashem. He is the ultimate klei kodesh. When he steps away from the Mizbeach, he cannot suddenly immerse himself in the ultimate symbol of human frailty and finality. Life is for the living, as they say, though usually that is just an excuse to take a second massive slice of overnight potato kugel at the Kiddush before the Rav finishes speaking. The Kohen has to maintain that constant state of chayus because his whole tafkid is to connect Klal Yisroel to the source of life. This necessity for perpetual freshness connects beautifully, mamash, to another fascinating din toward the end of our Parsha: the Lechem Hapanim. The posuk says we place twelve loaves on the Shulchan "lifnei Hashem tamid" (Vayikra 24:8). The Gemara (Menachos 96a) tells us a gevaldig fact: a great neis occurred with this bread. It was placed on the Shulchan on Shabbos, and when it was removed a week later, it was still as hot and fresh as the very moment it was baked! Now, any balabusta who has ever tried to serve week-old challah knows that unless you have a degree in advanced thermodynamics, it quickly turns into a blunt-force weapon. But here, the lechem defied nature. Why? Because in the Mishkan, in the immediate presence of Hashem, there is absolutely no concept of staleness. Just like the Kohen from our first topic is shielded from tumah, which is spiritual stagnation and the ultimate end of growth, the Lechem Hapanim is completely shielded from physical decay. Both are teaching us the exact same yesod: proximity to the Shechinah halts the natural process of entropy. Time only degrades things that are disconnected from eternity. When you are constantly plugged into the Source, you do not expire, and you certainly never get stale. The **practical takeaway** for us, the tzibbur, is perfectly clear. We may not be Kohanim dodging tumah, and our leftover Shabbos dips certainly go bad by Tuesday, but we can still apply this yesod to our ruchniyus. How often does our davening or our seder in learning become like week-old bread? Dry, incredibly hard to swallow, and mostly done out of rote habit. The chiyuv is to inject that Kohen-level chayus into our daily routine. If we approach our Avodah with the firm realization that we are standing lifnei Hashem, we can keep our spiritual lives piping hot and completely fresh, day after day. So, the next time you open your sefer or start Shmoneh Esrei, do not let it be a stale routine. Bring the heat of the Lechem Hapanim and the relentless vitality of the Kohanim.

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Shabbus Zmanim

Chestnut Ridge, NY

2:30 pm מנחה

6:26/7:35 pm (Early/Late) הדלקה

מנחה - קבלת שבת pm

7:53 pm שקיעה

4:19/4:41 am (16.1/72) עלות השחר

5:53 am נץ החמה

7:15 am שחרית

Hot kiddush & Shiur after davening

8:47/9:23 am ס"ז קריאת שמע

10:09/10:33 am ס"ז תפילה

12:53 pm חצות היום

1:28 pm מנחה גדולה (גר"א)

4:59 pm מנחה קטנה (גר"א)

6:27 pm פלג המנחה (גר"א)

מנחה pm

7:54 pm שקיעה

8:40/8:44 pm (8.5/50) צה"כ ר' משה

8:46 pm מעריב (52)

8:54/9:06 pm (60/72) צה"כ



Next Week's Zmanim

Chestnut Ridge, NY

2:30 pm מנחה

6:32/7:43 pm (Early/Late) הדלקה

8:01 pm שקיעה

7:15 am שחרית

8:02 pm שקיעה

8:54 pm מעריב (52)

This Week's Riddle

Riddle: In this parsha, which two laws involve the number seven - but the number seven is not mentioned in the description?

Answer: (1) A Kohen is allowed to become ritually impure upon the death of his seven close relatives (Vayikra 21:2-3 with Rash). (2) This parsha states the command to light the seven-branched menorah (Vayikra 24:4).



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משל ונמשל ב-AI תאמין? By Reb Gemini

Consider the following "Torah" thought, generated by Gemini: Did the AI get it right? Do you find it to be accurate? Or did the technology miss the boat?

Mashal: Rabosai, imagine our good friend, Reb Fishel. Fishel decides that this year, he is going to run a marathon. Not just any marathon, but a grueling fifty-mile race. Fishel goes all out. He purchases the most aerodynamic running shoes on the market, a sweatband that is completely halachically compliant, and a stopwatch that costs more than a decent shtreimel. On day one of his training, Fishel runs an entire mile. He feels fantastic, mamash like a new person. He comes home, drinks a protein shake that tastes remarkably like pulverized cardboard, and decides he has earned a rest. This rest lasts for precisely forty-seven days. Fishel is a busy man; he has a chavrusah to ignore and a daf to fall asleep during, after all. On day forty-nine, the day before the big race, Fishel stretches his hamstrings, runs one more mile to loosen up, and goes to sleep early. Day fifty arrives. Fishel shows up at the starting line, looking like a professional athlete. The starting gun goes off, Fishel sprints forward with immense bren, and exactly four hundred yards later, he collapses on the pavement, gasping for air and demanding a piece of kokosh cake. Why did Fishel fail so spectacularly? Because Fishel fundamentally misunderstood the nature of preparation. He thought possessing the right equipment and showing up with excellent kavanah was enough. He wanted the glory of the fiftieth day without the sweat of the forty-nine days in between.

Nimshal: This mashal perfectly encapsulates our Avodah during the days of Sefiras HaOmer, which we read about in Parshas Emor. The posuk states, "U'sefartem lachem mimachoras hashabbos... sheva shabbosos temimos tiheyne" (Vayikra 23:15). The Torah demands that these weeks be temimos, absolutely complete. The Gemara (Menachos 66a) learns from this word temimos that one must count both the days and the weeks, ensuring a flawless, unbroken chain. The Sefer HaChinuch (Mitzvah 306) explains the shresh of this mitzvah: when Klal Yisroel left Mitzrayim, their entire focus and deepest desire was to reach Har Sinai and receive the Torah. The counting is an expression of that burning anticipation. But anticipation alone is exactly like Fishel's fancy running shoes. It looks nice, but it does not get you anywhere. Sefiras HaOmer is not merely a countdown to a Yom Tov; it is a meticulous, day-by-day process of spiritual refinement. You cannot simply count day one, take a spiritual nap for six weeks, count day forty-nine, and expect the heavens to open for you on Shavuot. If you skip a day, the halacha tells us you lose the bracha (Shulchan Aruch, Orach Chayim 489:8). Why? Because a missing day means a missing rung on the ladder. You cannot jump over it. In the Litvish world, we often fall into the trap of looking for the brilliant chiddush or the emotional high of a massive siyum. We want the Matan Torah experience instantly. But the Torah warns us here that the only way to reach day fifty is through temimos—the daily, relentless, sometimes entirely uninspiring grind of showing up to the beis medrash every single day, whether you are tired, whether it is raining, or whether the coffee room is completely out of milk.

Practical Takeaway: The practical takeaway for the tzibbur is not to rely on the sudden bursts of ruchniyus that happen once in a while. We all know the Yid who buys a magnificent leather-bound Tikkun Leil Shavuot and assumes it will magically keep him awake at three in the morning, only to find himself using it as a very expensive pillow by chatzos. To avoid this, we must embrace the temimos. True shtarkus is not defined by the days you feel like a gadol; it is defined by a rainy Tuesday in the middle of a long zman when you drag yourself to your seder anyway. It is learning the daf when it is entirely incomprehensible. It is making sure that your davening is not just a race to Aleinu but a daily exercise in connection. Let us stop trying to skip to the finish line. Let us do the hard, daily work of Sefiras HaOmer so that when Shavuot finally arrives, we do not collapse at the starting line, but instead stand tall, completely prepared and worthy of receiving the Torah.

GOOD SHABBUS!